

PARVEEN NEGI



pending case has taken an interesting turn with the ministries of home and health contradicting each other and the court asking the Government to delegate an official from the solicitor-general's office to sort out the matter.

It is estimated that 8 per cent of the gay population is infected with HIV compared to less than 1 per cent of the general population. The petitioners and interveners in the case too are divided on the issue. The petitioner Naaz Foundation wants amendments to exclude same-sex intercourse done in private. Another NGO, Joint Action Committee Kannur, calls the entire AIDS epidemic a hoax perpetuated by multi-national drug companies. Last heard, the Centre was trying to reconcile differing opinions between its two ministries. The argument, it seems, will continue.

by Shafi Rahman

Getting it Straight

DELHI Kashmir on the boil, bomb blasts in Jaipur, Ahmedabad, Hyderabad and Bangalore, and infiltration from across the border. You'd think the Home Ministry has its hands full. But it's something else that is engaging North Block these days:

it's about whether a man can go to bed with another man. Health Minister Anbumani Ramadoss last week earned some rare kudos from the country's gay community when he called for the abolition of Section 377 of the Indian Penal Code that penalises

"all sexual activity against the order of nature".

Various gay right organisations had challenged the constitutional validity of Section 377 in the Delhi High Court. The Home Ministry, however, questions the petition on the ground that if the relevant section is deleted, "it would open the floodgates of delinquent behaviour". Now the long-

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

With nothing much happening at the WTO, there is speculation that Shivraj Patil will be shifted to Commerce to free Kamal Nath for the Madhya Pradesh polls. The WTO will give Patil the chance to do what he loves doing most: nothing.

VOICES



"I have wept, slept on the ground, been jailed and condemned for 43 years to make Jharkhand a reality. Nobody deserves chief ministership more than I."

Shibu Soren, Jharkhand Chief Minister

"Personally, I would like Musharraf to be around and see us flourish in Pakistan and make the country a success story. That would be the revenge of Benazir Bhutto."

Asif Ali Zardari, PPP leader

"The CPI(M) should not speak about growth as the party itself is responsible for thwarting industrial growth by calling strikes and bandhs."

Amar Singh, SP general secretary

"Sometimes in India, when the Olympics come, we are not preparing for success, we are preparing for failure. It's a matter of attitude, of thinking, and that needs to change."

Abhinav Bindra, Shooter and Olympic gold medal winner

"I am not a superstar and I am not saying this for effect. I'm here only to entertain people. I don't want to be No.1 or No.2. I just want to be alive and kicking in the film industry."

Akshay Kumar, actor